criticized. Modi himself once told me in March that year, ‘Yes, we need to do more, else people will not forgive us.’ Nature had delivered its verdict—the political leadership of the BJP was left with no choice but to heed the message. It wasn’t easy—a strong section of the state leadership remained opposed to Modi. In the end, it was the Advani–Vajpayee duo who pushed the decision with the support of the RSS.

On 7 October 2001, Modi became the first full-time RSS pracharak to be made a state chief minister. It hadn’t been an easy ride. Born in a lower middle-class family in Vadnagar in north Gujarat’s Mehsana district, Modi came from the relatively small Ghanchi community, an OBC caste involved in oil extraction. This was a state whose politics was dominated by the powerful landowning Patels. In early conversations, I never heard Modi speak of his caste background or his years in Vadnagar. He did speak, though, of his RSS mentors with great fondness. ‘Lakshman Inamdar, or Vakilsaab, is a Maharashtrian like you, he guided me always,’ Modi told me. ‘You should then speak better Marathi!’ I teased him.

A few days after he became chief minister I interviewed Modi on the challenges that were now before him. ‘We have to rebuild Gujarat and restore confidence in the people in our leadership,’ he said, sounding almost sage-like. I sensed that he had been waiting for this moment for years. Some of his critics have suggested that Modi ‘conspired’ to become chief minister. Veteran editor Vinod Mehta has claimed that Modi had met him with files against Keshubhai which he wanted him to publish. Clearly, this was one pracharak who was adept at the power game.

A pracharak, or ‘preacher’, is the backbone of the RSS-led Sangh Parivar. Mostly bachelors, they are expected to live a life of austerity and self-discipline. Modi wasn’t a typical pracharak—he was intensely political and ambitious. I had met several Gujarat BJP leaders who insisted Modi was constantly plotting to ‘fix’ them. Modi was also a loner—when I met him in the BJP central office in his wilderness years in the late 1990s, he was often alone. His contemporary, Govindacharya, would be surrounded by admirers; Modi preferred to be in the company of newspapers.